# Zitian Wang

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University of Virginia
Department of Economics
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Update: July 2026

## Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Virginia — 2021 – now

*Dissertation:* "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment"
*Committee:* Charles Holt, Po-Hsuan Lin, Peter Troyan, Noan Myung

M.A. in Economics, Columbia University — 2019 – 2020

*Thesis:* "Why Higher Education? A Review on Signaling, Human Capital, and Peer Effects"
*Advisor:* Irasema Alonso

B.A. in Economics and B.S. in Financial Mathematics, University of California, Los Angeles — 2015 – 2019

## Research Fields

Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization

## Job Market Paper

1. **Wang, Z.** (2026) "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment" [Slides]

## Working Papers

2. **Wang, Z.**, Ahmed, I., Unjitwattana, P., Xie, E.Y., Fong, M.-J. & Lin, P.-H. (2026) "Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games" **(First author)**. Revising at **European Economic Review**.
3. **Wang, Z.** (2025) "Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game" [Slides]

## Conference, Seminar and Workshop Presentations

2026 Economic Science Association World Meeting*, Economic Science Association North American Meeting*, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting*, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (CFXS)*, UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop

2025 Economic Science Association North American Meeting

(* scheduled)

## Research Grants

Director of Graduate Studies Research Grant (US$2,000), University of Virginia 2026
Graduate School of Arts & Sciences Council Grant (US$500), University of Virginia 2026

## Professional Activities

*Organizer*

UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop 2025 – now
UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Reading Group 2025 – now

*Research Experience*

Research assistant for Prof. Peter Troyan, University of Virginia 2026
Research assistant for Prof. Denis Nekipelov, University of Virginia 2023

*Summer School Attendance*

Chicago School in Experimental Economics, University of Chicago 2024

*Other Professional Experience*

Solution Assistant, Shenzhen Yunjing Zhilian Technology Co., Ltd., China 2025
Mentor in Economics, Polygence Research Program, Palo Alto 2020

## Teaching

*Instructor*

Intermediate Macroeconomics, University of Virginia (eval: 4.6/5) Spring 2026
Intermediate Macroeconomics, University of Virginia Fall 2025

*Teaching Assistant*

University of Virginia 2022 – 2026

- Principles of Microeconomics (eval: 4.3/5)
- Principles of Macroeconomics (eval: 4.1/5)
- Intermediate Microeconomics (eval: 4.4/5)
- Intermediate Macroeconomics (eval: 4.3/5)
- Global Financial Markets (eval: 3.9/5)
- Economics of Risk, Uncertainty, and Information

Columbia University Summer 2020

- Principles of Economics

## Skills

Python, oTree, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript
Chinese (native), English (fluent)
CFA Level I

## References

**Charles Holt**
Department of Economics
University of Virginia
holt@virginia.edu

**Po-Hsuan Lin**
Department of Economics
University of Virginia
plin@virginia.edu

**Peter Troyan**
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**Ana Fostel**
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## Abstract: Job Market Paper

### Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment

We develop a model of paid search prominence and test its predictions in a controlled laboratory experiment varying the prominence level. Two sellers bid in a second-price auction for a prominent position that confers a search cost advantage over the rival, then simultaneously post prices observable to the consumer, who searches sequentially. The prominent seller is predicted to price higher, a gap qualitatively confirmed by the experimental results. But prices are more dispersed than theory implies, compressing this gap. Consistent with theory, the price gap widens with the prominence level. Sellers systematically overbid relative to the rational benchmark. Consumers depart from optimal search in both directions, which partly rationalizes sellers' observed behavior. Efficiency modestly declines with the prominence level, and most surplus accrues to consumers and the platform.